

UPSC Philosophy Optional Paper 1 Simulation

QUESTION PAPER | Time: 3 Hours | Maximum Marks: 250

INSTRUCTIONS

1. The paper has two sections, A and B, and eight questions.
2. Question 1 and Question 5 are compulsory.
3. Answer three other questions, choosing at least one from each section.
4. Answer five questions in all. The marks carried by each subpart are indicated.

SECTION A - Socio-Political Philosophy

Q1 (COMPULSORY)

- (a) Discuss Kautilya's concept of sovereignty in the light of 'Danda-neety'. [10 marks]
- (b) "Toleration is not equality." Comment. [10 marks]
- (c) "Untouchability is a symptom of caste, not a synonym for it." Examine the significance of this distinction. [10 marks]
- (d) Comment on Plato's critique of Democracy. [10 marks]
- (e) Distinguish between economic growth, human development and social progress. Why does the distinction matter? [10 marks]

Q2

- (a) "The concept of supreme legal authority survives every criticism examined; the image of a determinate personal sovereign does not." Critically examine this verdict with reference to Bodin, Austin, Laski and Kautilya. [20 marks]
- (b) 'There is no permanent friend or permanent enemy.' Discuss this statement in the light of Kautilya's view on Sovereignty. [15 marks]
- (c) "Principled distance is superior to strict separation." Critically evaluate. [15 marks]

Q3

- (a) Assess the claim that misrecognition is an independent dimension of injustice rather than a consequence of material inequality. [20 marks]
- (b) "Fraternity is the least attended and most necessary of Ambedkar's three principles." Critically discuss. [15 marks]
- (c) Are monarchy and theocracy necessarily related? Discuss with reference to the theory of Divine Right. [15 marks]

Q4

- (a) "Neither the village nor centralised modernity is inherently emancipatory for caste." Examine this claim with reference to Gandhi and Ambedkar. [20 marks]
- (b) Does technological development lead to progress in the ethical standards of the society? Explain. [15 marks]
- (c) Critically evaluate Laski's view on sovereignty as a satisfactory position in political theory. [15 marks]

SECTION B - Philosophy of Religion

Q5 (COMPULSORY)

- (a) State and evaluate the proofs for the existence of God as propounded in Jainism. [10 marks]
- (b) "The Euthyphro dilemma refutes divine command theory but leaves theistic ethics standing." Discuss. [10 marks]
- (c) Distinguish between rebirth and reincarnation, and explain why the distinction matters for a comparative account of Indian soteriology. [10 marks]

(d) Can a religious utterance be both performative and truth-apt? Discuss with reference to prayer, confession and doctrinal assertion. [10 marks]

(e) Is Hinduism poly-theistic? Give reasons for your answer. [10 marks]

Q6

(a) Compare St. Thomas Aquinas' five ways of knowing God with the arguments of the Nyaya School of Indian Philosophy for the existence of God. [20 marks]

(b) Critically evaluate the Buddhist arguments against the existence of God as the creator of the world. [15 marks]

(c) Can a non-theistic religion retain worship, transcendence and liberation without covertly reintroducing God? Discuss. [15 marks]

Q7

(a) "Religion supplies morality with motivation and scope; morality supplies religion with a standard. Neither supplies the other with a foundation." Critically evaluate. [20 marks]

(b) Critically examine the idea of Brahman in Advaita philosophy of Samkara. Does Samkara's conception of Brahman leave room for theism? Discuss. [15 marks]

(c) Assess the claim that moral criticism of religious practice is necessarily an external, secular imposition. [15 marks]

Q8

(a) Critically compare the Semitic doctrine of resurrection with the Indian doctrine of rebirth, and assess whether either succeeds in securing the identity of the person who survives. [20 marks]

(b) The problem of evil is a direct offshoot of how God is conceptualised in a system." Critically discuss. [15 marks]

(c) What is the logical problem of evil? Discuss. [15 marks]

END OF PAPER